

Kandinsky

The achievements of Russian Wassily Kandinsky (1866–1944) changed the path of art. His explorations of colour, shape and abstraction evolved from his synaesthesia – the capacity to ‘see’ sound and ‘hear’ colour – and his study of Theosophy, a system of beliefs that explore divine meanings and spirituality. To spread his ideas, Kandinsky wrote, taught and started art movements and groups, moving from Russia to Germany where he co-founded Der Blaue Reiter and later taught at the Bauhaus from 1922 to 1933.

Influenced by Russian folk art, Art Nouveau, Impressionism, Post-Impressionism, Fauvism and music, Kandinsky moved increasingly towards abstraction, based on intellectual ideas rather than an instinctive approach. He began distorting images, using bright unnatural colours, obscuring the subject matter and ultimately discarding it altogether, with colour, shape and a sense of dynamism taking its place. He rigorously planned compositions to evoke his convictions in art’s ability to regenerate the world, and colour’s power to provoke psychological responses in viewers.



Kandinsky, *Composition IV*, 1911